



Just 20 years ago OCD was considered a **rare disorder**, affecting only 0.5% people

Now it is believed to affect 2-3% of the total **population** and 1% children

OCD is one of the 10 leading causes of **disability**, reports WHO

Over **12 million** Indians have it in one form or another

58% patients seeking treatment come from an **urban** background

Average time lag between onset and a proper diagnosis is **17 years**

COMMON COMPULSIONS

Washing and cleaning	41%
Checking	38%
Repeating	16%
Ordering	16%
Counting	5%
Hoarding	3%

COMMON OBSESSIONS

Contamination	45%
Pathologic doubt	35%
Aggression	32%
Sex	20%
Religious	17%
Symmetry/exactness	14%
Hoarding	3%

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH imaging MADHU BHASKAR

other. "New frontiers in gene research, scanning technologies and treatments have opened up. They are proving more effective than ever," says Reddy. "About 40 per cent recover and 30 per cent show fair improvement."

Madness is just a millimetre away from sanity, they say. For OCD, that gap is thinner. No other mental disorder hides as stealthily for years, masquerades as something else, delays diagnosis, or causes as much silent, embarrassed suffering as the neurochemical storm that is OCD.

But what is it? You know it when you spend an entire day washing your hands for fear of some contamination. You know it when you shrink from the sight of a kitchen knife, worried that you will inexplicably snatch it up and hurt yourself or a family member. You know it when leaving office consumes hours because the files on your desk must be placed just right. You know it when you can't throw out old newspapers for fear that you may need them in future. You know it when you can't help making lewd comments to every

woman you pass by. You know it when you re-read, re-write, re-calculate, re-do things over and over again.

Call them "mental hiccups". OCD throws up persistent, distressing thoughts, images and ritual behaviours that a person is driven to perform. "Everyone has intrusive thoughts, but most people can ignore those and move on with their lives. For those with OCD, the thoughts become their lives," says Dr Ramesh Sagar, associate professor of psychiatry at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi. It's an

The Journal of Clinical Psychiatry, 2006, NIMHANS, Dr Y.C. Janardhan Reddy et al